So I kept thinking and kept hoping and eventually I pressed the emergency button.

They allowed me to see the Governor. He decided I should be in the Onslow Wing with the ‘at risk’ prisoners. Several storeys high and several cells deep, the wing has its own culture within the prison. It seemed I should go there because, in the Governor’s opinion, I was at risk of being attacked by other prisoners. It was a strange assumption, because the prisoners I met were quite clearly on my side. In Onslow, the landings were filled with rapists and paedophiles, crime bosses, the occasional celebrity. I was alone in the cell and still had no phone allowance. No phone and no writing materials and no chance of talking with my colleagues. I stood in the cell feeling defiant but ill equipped.

The cell was down in the basement, about two metres by four, with a bed, a washbasin, a toilet, a desk, a closet and off-white walls. Much of the wall space was taken up by a drab grey plastic structure that formed the water and ventilation system for the washbasin and toilet. These were designed to minimise the possibility of self-harm, but this also meant that everything was dull, smoothed off, and hidden. There were no taps in the washbasin, no flush handle on the toilet, no cistern. Everything was automated or operated by touch. There was a medical emergency button on the wall by the bed and a curtain to pull around the toilet. At the top of one wall was a small window, with bars across it at four-centimetre intervals, that looked out onto the prison exercise yard, a small space enclosed by a high mesh fence, topped with layers of razor wire. Sometimes in the mornings I would see the legs of prisoners in the yard passing by the window, hear shouts, snatches of jokes and conversation. Above the cell door an infrared surveillance camera looked into the room, armed with a bank of LED lights that glowed a dull red throughout the night, constantly watching. The cell door was unmarked apart from a single spyhole in its centre, covered on the outside by a metal flap.

The other prisoners were curious about me, so the metal flap on the cell door was constantly being flipped up as they looked in to see what I was doing. There’s a film of Robert Bresson’s called *A Man Escaped*, a beautiful film, but really a feat of sound engineering, where a spoon struck against brickwork can seem orchestral. Every sound was like that in Wandsworth: full of echo and emptiness. The metal flap scraped as it was lifted and I sensed an eye. Yes. They wanted to see what I was up to in my